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Uncertainty marks session’s last weekend

Illinois lawmakers debate Bears stadium, gas tax and budget

By **Jeremy Gorner, Dan Petrella, Jack O'Connor and Olivia Olander**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — Staring down a month-end adjournment deadline, Illinois state lawmakers convened Friday in an atmosphere of indecision, with the fate of tax breaks

to keep the Chicago Bears in Illinois and a new state budget still unresolved as myriad closed-door negotiations spread throughout the Capitol.

Also on the docket was a possible suspension of a state gas tax hike set to take effect on July 1 amid skyrocketing gasoline prices due to the U.S. war in Iran, and efforts to increase housing.

The lack of movement on the major issues has increased tensions and exposed internal dissension among Democratic lawmakers,

who hold supermajorities in the House and Senate, toward their legislative leaders and Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker, who is vying for a third term in November.

Progressive Democrats and some moderate Democrats are pushing for new taxes to offset cuts Pritzker proposed in his budget plan and to partially counter reductions to federal social programs that the Trump administration has targeted at Democratic-run states.

But for other Democrats, any kind of a tax hike is anathema in an

election year.

Emerging midday from the governor’s second-floor Capitol office alongside House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch after a roughly hourlong meeting with Pritzker, Senate President Don Harmon said Democratic leaders still were finalizing a spending plan for the coming budget year.

Harmon said that reaching an agreement would require working through “an infinite request for spending and a finite amount of resources,” though he did not spec-

ify which components of the budget were still being worked out.

‘STILL WORKING’ ON BEARS

While passage of a budget is considered virtually inevitable despite internal squabbles, legislative action on a measure to keep the Bears from moving to Hammond, Indiana, is still being negotiated to satisfy a variety of interests.

“Still working on it,” Harmon said of the so-called megaprojects bill

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Mayor Brandon Johnson presents Pope Leo XIV with Chicago-themed gifts during his visit on Thursday at the Vatican. **SIMONE RISOLUTI/VATICAN MEDIA**

A landmark decision

Johnson floats street naming or other formal recognition in Chicago for Pope Leo XIV

By **Alice Yin**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ROME — Fresh off the glow of his summit with Pope Leo XIV at the Vatican, Mayor Brandon Johnson signaled Friday that Chicago could be due for another street or landmark christened after a pontiff.

In a sit-down interview with the

Tribune, Johnson said the first American pope deserves to be formally recognized in his hometown, though he said it was premature to commit to whether that should manifest in a road designation or other type of monument.

“It’s an incredible honor, right, to have the most recognizable, influential religious leader in the world to be from Chicago,” Johnson said from a cafe in

Rome. “There will be plenty of ways in which we’ll be able to honor our dear brother, His Holiness.”

In Brighton Park, 43rd Street between Western and Kedzie avenues was named after Pope John Paul II, the first Polish-born pope who was especially beloved by the Polish immigrant community on the Southwest Side. He was also the last pontiff to visit Chicago, celebrating an

hourslong Mass in Grant Park in 1979 that Johnson called “the most spiritually inspiring day in Chicago history” in his Thursday invitation for Leo to make a similar pilgrimage to the city next year.

Johnson landed in Rome Thursday morning as part of the most high-profile international trip of his mayoral term.

See **POPE** on Page A6

‘Just simple and beautiful’

Six Flags Great America in Gurnee marks 50 years as summer destination

By **Joseph States**
PIONEER PRESS

Sitting in his office, Gurnee Mayor Tom Hood can see Six Flags Great America in the distance through his window. Both his childhood home and his house today are within a mile of the park that dominates the village skyline.

Some days, he can even hear the cheerful screams of parkgoers in the air.

Hood grew up in Gurnee, as did his mother, and he still remembers

the small, sleepy town it was before 1976. Hood was 16 when the theme park dropped into his backyard, kickstarting the transformation of the placid farming community with a population of 3,300 at the time.

From a flurry of construction and dust rose something never before seen in the small village: steel towers holding aloft winding tracks that towered above the landscape, buildings covered in dazzling colors and lights, and a sea of asphalt that would soon provide parking for hundreds of vehicles.

It was Marriott’s Great America, and advertisements in the Chicago Tribune in the spring of 1976 promised “a whole new country of fun.” Thematically, the park was a nostalgic throwback, with a classic — if sometimes kitschy — presentation of American iconography and history.

But for Gurnee, which Tribune reporter Robert Cross described as a “semirural settlement of no particular distinction” in 1976, it was a powerful force that drove the village



Visitors ride Sky Striker at Six Flags Great America on May 16 in Gurnee. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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Charter school renewals delayed

The Chicago Board of Education voted to delay contract renewals for six of seven operators, as board members sparred about oversight. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

No decision yet on Iran deal

President Donald Trump left a meeting with his advisers without a decision as he pondered moving forward with a deal to extend the Iran ceasefire. **Nation & World**

High hopes for Bears’ Burden

Coach Ben Johnson is “buying Luther Burden stock right now” after “electric” offseason of work for the second-year wide receiver. **Chicago Sports**

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